three weeks. Ratan met around eighty family members and communicated his heartfelt condolences. He also assessed the adequacy of the relief package that the Taj HR department had formulated against the requirement of each individual family.

The extent to which Ratan wanted to help these families surprised even his staff. He was more benevolent than what those affected had hoped for. Kang recalls that after the dust had settled, the hotel staff had presented an initial proposal to Ratan for the rehabilitation. He responded, ‘Is this enough?’ He was unlike any other business leader. Most would have wanted to cut, trim and prune the benefits, reasoning that the company could not afford it, feels Kang, who has seen scores of CEOs and industry leaders.

Thevar, who had saved the Swiss couple, airs a similar opinion. He was invited to a function at the Taj Chambers where some British Consular officials had gathered to thank the staff. There, he saw Ratan and walked up to him and thanked him. Recalling the instance, an emotionally overwhelmed Thevar, with tears in his eyes, says in a choked voice: ‘But I will never forget in my life what he said. He said, “May God give me the strength. I wish to do more.”’

The Taj employees who had lost their lives were given financial compensation ranging from Rs 36 lakh to Rs 85 lakh. For every Taj employee who died in the attack, the spouse became eligible for the full salary until their own death. Besides, the company decided to pay the education fees for the children of the deceased, extended full medical facilities for the whole family for the rest of their lives and appointed a counsellor for life for each person.

The families of the deceased could also retain their official accommodation until the time the deceased would normally have retired. All loans and advances taken by the deceased were waived, irrespective of the amounts involved. Batliwala also adds that the children of those who had lost their lives were offered employment in any of the Tata companies of their choice. Importantly, all the Taj employees were assigned a mentor whose responsibility was to act as a ‘single window clearance’ for any help that they needed.

During the restoration period, Ratan also ensured that the entire staff received their salaries, though the hotel was not functional. ‘Profits are not his only priority,’ comments Kang.